

PTI

J&K

130+
DEATH TOLL

₹3,000 cr.
OFFICIAL LOSS ESTIMATE

702 mm
AGGREGATE RAINFALL*

37%
EXCESS RAIN

* For the period Jun. 1-Sept. 15, 2025; Source: IMD

"THE RELEASE FROM BHAKRA AND PONG [DAMS] HAS BEEN THE HIGHEST IN HISTORY," ADMITS BBMB CHAIRMAN MANOJ TRIPATHI. IT COULDN'T BE HELPED; BETWEEN JULY 1 AND SEPT. 5, THE BEAS ALONE GOT 11.7 BILLION CU. M. OF INFLOW

growers, the losses are crushing. Shimla and Kullu reported Rs 126 crore in orchard damage, with 35,121 growers in Shimla and 10,908 in Kullu hit. Unlike Punjab's prolonged misery, destruction came in violent surges here, carrying away entire valleys in minutes. The Beas, Sutlej and Parvati rivers swelled beyond capacity, and along with lax early-warning systems turned climate shocks into cascading disasters. The Himachal State Disaster Management Authority calculates overall economic losses at over Rs 4,100 crore, spanning homes, shops, livestock sheds and public infrastructure. This comes even as recovery from the 2023 floods—then pegged at Rs 9,500 crore—remains incomplete despite central aid of Rs 2,006 crore and state allocations of Rs 4,500 crore.

CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, walking through relief camps caked in mud, announced immediate cash assistance of Rs 10,000 per affected family, while compensation slabs were set higher. With an annual budget of only Rs 57,000 crore, Sukhu quickly demanded a Rs 12,000 crore special package from the Centre. "We cannot fight climate calamities with 10-year-old relief norms," he declared in Shimla. Which is where talk turns to the structural bind. The Union government's NDRFs (National Disaster Response Funds) and SDRFs still operate on relief slabs last revised in 2015-16: Rs 95,100 for a fully damaged house, Rs 37,500 per cow, Rs 13,500 per hectare for crop loss (capped at 2 ha.). Families who lost members are entitled to Rs 60,000. It also insists on strict cost-sharing ratios; for example, 75:25 with Punjab, 90:10 for Himachal. But these numbers are divorced from today's realities. Even in rural Himachal, rebuilding a house costs Rs 8-10 lakh; apple orchards and livestock are worth several times the compensation announced. "Relief barely covers 30 per cent of the value lost," says Rajesh Chauhan of the Himachal Apple Growers Association. "It feels like a symbolic gesture."

NATURE'S WRATH IN J&K

After the mega floods of 2014, J&K saw its worst natural disaster this year, with over 130 people dead and 33 missing. The Jhelum raged in full spate, prompting evacuations in Anantnag, Pulwama and Srinagar. Bridges in Baramulla and Kupwara were washed away, isolating villages, while the strategic Srinagar-Jammu national highway had to be closed temporarily due to landslides in Ramban district, leaving hundreds of vehicles stranded. Even the cold desert of Ladakh, now a separate UT and normally a rainshadow region of the Himalayas, is fighting the sludge after some 434 per cent excess rainfall this year.

Official assessments show 13,000 ha. (32,000 acres) affected statewide, with paddy fields and fruit orchards devastated. The wider infrastructure collapse compounds the agrarian distress. About 12,000 km of roads are damaged. The collapse